survived six months. Could Léa endure a year? She pressed the heel of her hands against her eyes. *Don't cry. Never cry.* She'd said those words when her mother died. *Don't let Rose see you cry*. She drew a long breath, letting it settle, giving her time to put on the mask she always wore as a shield for both of them. She lowered her hands.

"I see," Léa said, her voice tight.

Rose fidgeted in the metal chair. "Maître Mallon has a proposition for you."

"There's a place you can go," he said. "It might be better than here. Not perfect."

Léa leaned forward. "Where?"

"A place where you'd be paid to work."

"A prison in another town?" Léa stared hard at him, trying to figure out why he was being evasive.

"Not a prison, but in another country. The German Employment Office in Orléans is actively recruiting women with criminal convictions to work in German factories."

Léa bristled. "No—"

"The conditions are—"

"I'd be working for the enemy!" She couldn't fathom betraying her country.

"Germany needs labor to run their factories," Maître Mallon said in the official, calm notarial voice that she'd always found reassuring, until now. "You will have a contract, be given food, medical care, a salary, a pension, and your criminal conviction will be wiped from the record."

"No, no, no. I've never worked for the Germans, and I won't start now." She folded her arms and looked at Rose, who stared back with confusion in her eyes.

"You don't have to do anything you don't want to," Rose said softly, her voice trembling.

"Think about it," Maître Mallon said. "The employment conditions are bad in France. The money men and women working in Germany send back is what keeps their families alive."

"But it keeps the war running too!" Rose burst out.

Maître Mallon had said from the beginning that she needed to harden herself and do what was right for Rose. Was he telling her now that going to